

Baylor - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG 12

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ◆ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Middle-tier Power 4 / bowl-line quality with offensive upside around DJ Lagway, but a defense that must improve materially for Baylor to move beyond the middle of the Big 12.
Preseason consensus	AP unranked (0 votes/points) · SP+ No. 54
Returning production	54% (No. 62) overall · Off. 45% (No. 98) · Def. 62% (No. 22)
Primer power rating	+4.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	5.9 wins · most likely 6-6
Net vs. 2025	● ↔ Similar - Similar, with a slightly higher defensive ceiling but a wide implementation range
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: OC Jake Spavital features QB DJ Lagway, RB Dawson Pendergrass and more vertical passing behind a rebuilt line. New DC Joe Klanderman installs a disguise/disruption-focused 4-2-5 with a transfer-heavy front.

Bottom line: Baylor has enough quarterback, offensive and special-teams quality to reach a bowl and threaten a higher ceiling, but the Bears remain a volatile middle-tier team until the rebuilt offensive line and new-look defense prove they can survive down-to-down.

Beats expectations if: Lagway gives Spavital efficient vertical production, the new OL settles despite Walker's unavailability, and Klanderman turns a portal-heavy front into a much more disruptive third-down/red-zone defense.

Disappoints if: The offense loses too much from Robertson/Cameron/Washington/line departures, the new front never fixes the 2025 run-defense and success-rate problems, and Wheeler's legal status or other newcomer volatility destabilizes the defensive plan.

Five things to remember

- ★ **QB DJ Lagway:** QB DJ Lagway is the high-confidence projected starting quarterback and carries a Maxwell Award signal.
- 2025 baseline:** The 2025 offense was productive by raw yardage/scoring, but the advanced profile was less dominant: opponent-adjusted offense No.62, success rate No.60 and explosive-play rate No.113.
- Coaching:** Joe Klanderman is the new defensive coordinator and explicit defensive play-caller; Dave Aranda has relinquished game-day defensive calls.
- ? **OL questions:** The offensive line was reshuffled after OL Yakiri Walker's eligibility relief was denied; OL Koltin Sieracki moved toward center and multiple incoming linemen are in the projected first group.
- ★ **P Palmer Williams:** P Palmer Williams is a rare stability/strength point: AP second team, Walter Camp first team, Big 12 first team and Ray Guy recognition, while SP+ ranks Baylor special teams No. 2.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	5-7 (3-6 Big 12)	● Poor
Scoring	31.1 PPG	● Very good
Total offense	451.1 YPG	● Very good
Rush offense	141.5 YPG · 4.1 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass efficiency	7.27 YPA · 31 TD / 12 INT	● Average / mixed
Third downs	37.6%	● Below average
Scoring defense	32.6 PPG allowed	● Very poor
Total defense	392.1 YPG allowed	● Below average
Rush defense	197.2 YPG · 4.9 YPC	● Very poor
Pass defense	194.9 YPG · 6.80 YPA · 17 TD allowed	● Average / mixed

The offense carried Baylor: scoring No.33 and total offense No.18 despite only average rushing and below-average third downs. The defense was the opposite, with scoring defense No.122, rush defense No.122 and total defense No.88.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+0.57 · No. 62	● Average / mixed
Off. EPA/play	+0.044 · No. 49	● Good / above average
Off. success rate	43.1% · No. 60	● Average / mixed
Off. explosive-play rate	10.3% · No. 113	● Poor
Havoc allowed	15.1% · No. 63	● Average / mixed
Opp.-adjusted defense	-1.64 · No. 79	● Average / mixed
Def. EPA/play allowed	+0.029 · No. 77	● Average / mixed
Def. success rate allowed	44.8% · No. 114	● Poor
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	11.3% · No. 47	● Good / above average
Havoc created	11.9% · No. 129	● Very poor

Advanced-stat read: The offense’s raw production exceeded its adjusted/play-level profile. Defensively, poor success-rate prevention and No. 129 havoc creation were the core problems.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Dave Aranda - returning	● ↔ Maintains program leadership and defensive identity; improvement must come from execution rather than a reset.
OC / play-caller	Jake Spavital - returning OC/QBs; is the offensive play-caller	● ↔ The same coordinator and play-caller preserves offensive structure and reduces transition risk.
DC / play-caller	◆ Joe Klanderman - new from Kansas State DC/S; explicitly assigned defensive calls	● ↑ Transition with upside; caller established

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ QB DJ Lagway	Florida	● ↔ High-confidence projected starter with Maxwell recognition.
◆ WR Dre'Ion Miller	Colorado	● ↔ Projected first-group receiver in a room replacing multiple departures to professional football.
◆ WR Gavin Freeman	Oklahoma State	● ↔ Expected first-group receiver and meaningful part of the rebuilt pass-game composition.
◆ TE Tony Livingston	Florida	● ↔ Likely starting tight end replacing departed NFL-path production.

Out	To	Loss
QB Sawyer Robertson	NFL (Las Vegas), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Material 2025 quarterback production leaves via confirmed UDFA signing.
WR Josh Cameron	NFL (Jacksonville), Round 6, No. 191	● ↓ Baylor's 2025 leader in catches, yards and receiving touchdowns departs as a sixth-round pick.
RB Bryson Washington	Auburn	● ↓ 2025 rushing-workload leader (788 yards, six TDs) transfers out.
OL Coleton Price	Kentucky	● ↓ Eleven-game starting center departs, increasing the importance of the Sieracki/transfer OL reshuffle.

Offensive net: ● ↓ slight downgrade in stability despite Lagway upside

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ DE Jordan Mack	Coastal Carolina	● ↔ Projected first-group defensive end in a transfer-heavy front.
◆ DL Kamren Washington	Texas State	● ↔ Expected first-group defensive tackle; part of the front-seven reset.
◆ DL Hosea Wheeler	Indiana	● ↔ Likely nose tackle, but 2026 eligibility is currently protected only by a temporary injunction and must remain caveated.
◆ JACK Garrick Ponder	Southern Miss	● ↔ Anticipated starting JACK adds immediate-role transfer talent.

Out	To	Loss
LB Keaton Thomas	Ole Miss	● ↓ Twelve-game starter and 103-tackle linebacker departs.
DL Jackie Marshall	NFL (Tennessee), Round 6, No. 184	● ↓ Material defensive-line contributor departs as a sixth-round draft pick.

Defensive net: ● ↑ potential upgrade with a wide projection range

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Spavital offense seeking more vertical and middle-field passing around Lagway, with RB Dawson Pendergrass as the lead run-game reference point.	Quarterback upside, a proven lead-back role and enough receiving additions to preserve multiplicity.	A rebuilt offensive line and major 2025 production losses at QB/WR/RB/TE; the unit can be talented without being immediately cohesive.
Defense	Klanderman 4-2-5 emphasizing simplicity, line-of-scrimmage disruption, disguise, explosive-play prevention and third-down/red-zone execution.	The 2025 defense already limited explosive plays relatively well (No.47), and the new first group adds multiple transfer starters around Barnes/Reed and returning secondary pieces.	Down-to-down defense and disruption: 2025 success rate allowed ranked No.114, havoc created No.129 and rush defense No.122.
Special teams	Punting-led strength with one of the best preseason special-teams model signals in the country.	P Palmer Williams has first-team national/conference recognition and Ray Guy watch context; SP+ special teams ranks No.2.	Kicker is less proven/settled than punter.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B	● ↔	Medium-high	QB DJ Lagway brings high-upside starter talent with Maxwell recognition.
RB	● B-	● ↓	Medium	RB Dawson Pendergrass takes the lead role after RB Bryson Washington leaves.
WR	● B-	● ↓	Medium	WR Louis Brown IV anchors a room replacing its top 2025 target.
TE	● C+	● ↓	Medium	TE Tony Livingston replaces departed major production.
OL	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	OL Koltin Sieracki anchors a reshuffled, transfer-heavy five.
DL/Edge	● B-	● ↑	Medium-low	DL Hosea Wheeler headlines a rebuilt front with legal-status uncertainty.
LB	● B-	● ↔	Medium-high	LB Travion Barnes anchors the second level after a major departure.
Secondary	● B-	● ↔	Medium	CB Devon Jordan adds to a returning secondary core.
Special teams	● A-	● ↔	High	P Palmer Williams has first-team national/conference recognition and Ray Guy watch context; SP+ special teams ranks No.2.
Coaching	● B	● ↔	Medium	OC Jake Spavital returns; DC Joe Klanderman is the major change.
Overall	● B-	● ↔	Medium-low	Middle-tier Power Four quality with DJ Lagway-driven offensive upside, but the defense must improve for Baylor to rise in the Big 12.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Palmer Williams	P	● National specialist	AP second team · Walter Camp first team · Big 12 first team · Ray Guy	Forced Players-to-Know recognition player and the clearest elite unit anchor on the roster.
◆ DJ Lagway (TR: Florida)	QB	● High-upside Power 4 starter	Maxwell	Projected starter and the biggest variable in preserving Baylor's offensive ceiling after major 2025 departures.
Travion Barnes	LB	● High-end conference linebacker	Bednarik	Returning projected MLB and the most recognized non-specialist defender.
Dawson Pendergrass	RB	● Solid Power 4 lead back	-	Projected lead runner after RB Bryson Washington's transfer departure.
Louis Brown IV	WR	● Solid Power 4 starter projection	-	Returning first-group receiver in a room replacing multiple NFL-path departures.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Koltin Sieracki	OL	● Key continuity lineman / center projection	-	Shifted toward center after Walker's eligibility denial and now anchors an otherwise transfer-heavy projected five.
◆ Hosea Wheeler (TR: Indiana)	DL	● Projected starting nose tackle / legal-status monitor	-	Important transfer projected at nose, but current eligibility is temporary-injunction dependent.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Manageable enough for a bowl push, but not soft: Baylor has many true swing games and a difficult closing three-game stretch.
Difficulty	● 6/10 · Moderate · SP+ SOS No. 43
Hardest stretch	at BYU → Texas Tech → at Houston (Nov. 14-28)
Swing games	Colorado, at Arizona State, TCU, at Kansas, at UCF, Iowa State, at Houston
Advantage	Prairie View A&M and Louisiana Tech at home follow the neutral-site opener, and the Oct. 10 bye precedes TCU.
Expected	5.9 wins · most likely 6-6
Floor / ceiling	4-8 / 8-4

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	Baylor is a volatility team: recognizable QB upside and elite special-teams signal can attract interest, but the transfer-heavy OL/defense and weak 2025 defensive down-to-down profile argue against paying a premium before the reset proves itself.
Back them when	Prefer Baylor when the price treats the Bears as a generic sub-.500 team but the matchup lets Lagway attack vertically without overwhelming OL stress, especially if early evidence shows Klanderman has improved third-down/disruption performance.
Fade/pass when	Fade or pass when an opponent can consistently stress the rebuilt line or run game against Baylor's new front, or when the market prices Lagway/name recognition as if the offense's 45% returning-production signal and defense's reset risk do not matter.
Key monitor	OL Yakiri Walker eligibility, DL Hosea Wheeler injunction, OL cohesion, defensive success rate/havoc
Week 1 baseline	Baylor +7.5 vs. Auburn (neutral) · rating-only baseline; Baylor primer +4.0 minus Auburn primer +11.5; no home-field, matchup or availability adjustment. Compare with the live market before betting. Live market: Baylor +7.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Baylor’s upside starts with QB DJ Lagway and an offense that still has enough skill talent to score, while P Palmer Williams gives the Bears an elite special-teams anchor. The rebuilt OL is the main obstacle to turning that upside into dependable efficiency.

DC Joe Klanderman’s defense must improve ordinary-down success and havoc without losing explosive-play prevention. That makes **5.9 wins and 6-6** a fair baseline for a volatile bowl-line team with a higher ceiling if the defensive reset takes quickly.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [coaching](#) · [departures](#) · [current update](#) · [current update 2](#) · [current update 3](#) · [current update 4](#)

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